

Sometimes, You Have to Find Solutions That Don't Exist"

ARUNDHATI BHATTACHARYA
Former Chairperson, SBI; Chairperson & CEO, Salesforce India

BHATTACHARYA JOINED SALESFORCE as Chairperson and CEO of Salesforce India in April 2020, a week after India's Covid-19 lockdown began. She had expected the disruption to last a month or two. Instead, remote work became the norm, and she had to navigate a new organisation and a different way of working after four decades in corporate life—from the corner of her bedroom!

"Forty years of corporate life had not prepared me for doing my job from a corner of my bedroom," she says.

At SBI, Bhattacharya saw this in Girls Forever, a group of serving and retired women employees who have pursued interests ranging from painting and poetry to publishing and board positions. One member became the second runner-up at Mrs India after retirement.

"When we were in our earlier jobs, we focused on mentoring. In this role, I have experienced reverse mentoring on a scale I would never have imagined," she says. "I now firmly believe that reverse mentoring is necessary."

Earlier in her career, security had been her primary objective. Today, she sees it more broadly, encompassing society, the environment and the planet.

Her views on career transitions are shaped by the difficult choices she faced as a working mother. When her aunt, who was helping care for her daughter, had to return to India, Bhattacharya had to find an alternative care arrangement. Later, a posting to Lucknow raised another dilemma: how to manage her daughter's schooling without separating the family.

Bhattacharya is equally clear that staying in a career is not the only valid choice.

Women may decide to retire, pursue a passion or move on to something else. What matters is that the decision is genuinely theirs.

Today, she has more control over her mornings, time for exercise, leisurely lunches, and reading. Through difficult transitions, she has held on to one simple belief: "Humour is the lubricant of life."